

TODAY'S 1-HOUR CLINIC

Get the Ball Close From Around the Green

Welcome. The short game is where scores are made — for most players, more than half of all shots happen from inside 40 yards. In our hour together we build **one reliable shot** — we'll call it your **Foundation Shot** — and then learn to make small, sensible adjustments for whatever the course gives you.

Master one shot first. Everything else is a small tweak on top of it.

1 Long Putts

Grip & rolling it close

2 Chipping

The Foundation Shot

3 Pitching

Same shot, bigger swing

SECTION 1

Long Putts — Rolling It Close

On long putts, stop trying to make it. Your job is to cozy the ball into a **3-foot circle** around the hole so you're left with a tap-in. Almost every 3-putt comes from poor **speed**, not a poor read — so speed is what we train.

How to hold the putter

- **Palms face each other.** Set both hands on the grip so your palms look at one another — like they're going to clap. This lets the putter face swing squarely.
- **Thumbs point straight down the top.** Run both thumbs down the flat front of the grip. This quiets the hands and stops the face twisting.
- **Let the hands touch / interlace.** A common, easy option is the “reverse overlap”: rest your lead-hand index finger over the fingers of your trail hand so the two hands work as one unit.
- **Soft pressure — about 4 out of 10.** Light hands feel the weight of the putter head. A tight grip kills your touch and distance control.

Getting the speed right

- **Look at the hole, not the ball, while you rehearse.** Make 2–3 practice strokes looking at the target — like tossing a ball underhand. Your body naturally sizes the stroke to the distance.
- **Longer putt = longer stroke, same smooth tempo.** Match the length of your backstroke and through-stroke, and keep the same unhurried rhythm every time.
- **Pick a spot to “land” it,** then let it roll out to the hole. Aim to die the ball into that 3-foot circle.
- **From off the green, consider putting instead of chipping** (“the Texas wedge”). A so-so putt usually finishes closer than a so-so chip.

DRILL — The 3-Foot Circle

Drop 5 balls at 30, 40 and 50 feet. Forget the line. Score a point every time a ball finishes inside an imaginary 3-foot circle around the hole. Beat your score next time. This is how you erase 3-putts.

SECTION 1 • STILL PUTTING

How You Hold It Is a Preference — Not a Rule

Every player below has won at the very top of the game — and every one holds the putter **differently**. There is no single “correct” putting grip. The job of *any* grip is the same: keep your hands quiet so the face stays square and your speed stays consistent. Try a few — keep whichever lets you roll it smooth.



Lee Westwood
The Claw

Trail hand pinches the grip claw-like between thumb and forefinger so it stays passive and can't twist the face.



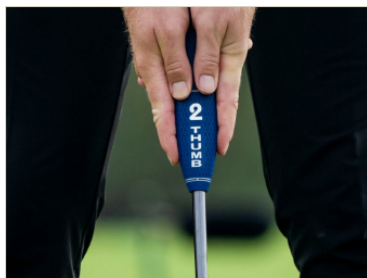
Bryson DeChambeau
The Arm Lock

Grip runs up against the lead forearm so wrist and putter move as one locked unit. Took him from 145th to 28th in putting.



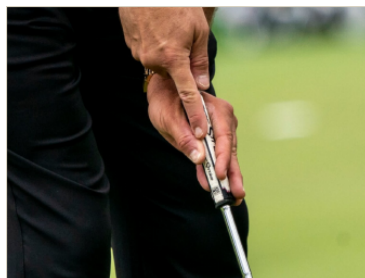
Jordan Spieth
Left-Hand Low

Lead hand sits below the trail hand (cross-handed). Levels the shoulders and lets the lead hand control the path.



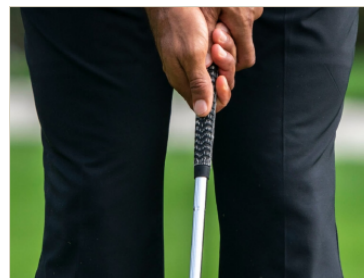
Matt Wallace
Two Thumbs

Palms face each other, both thumbs down the top of the grip. Hands hang even for a pure pendulum. The "prayer" grip.



Phil Mickelson
Lefty Claw

A claw for a left-handed player: the trail hand points down the grip for a longer, smoother stroke on fast greens.



Tiger Woods
Reverse Overlap

The most common grip in golf. The lead forefinger lies across the trail-hand fingers to unite both hands.



Brooks Koepka
Alt. Reverse Overlap

Same idea, but the trail forefinger points straight down the shaft so the wrist angle never changes through the stroke.



Adam Scott
Long Putter Claw

A longer putter played with a right-hand-low claw — no longer anchored to the chest, but still long and stable.



Justin Rose
Modified Claw

Two trail-hand fingers rest over the top of the grip instead of the side. His reason: "It feels simpler."

Bottom line: pick the quiet grip you can repeat — then own it. (Grip photos: The New York Times.)

SECTION 2

Chipping — Your Foundation Shot

The chip is the shot everything else is built on. It's a small shot that flies low and rolls out. We're after the same, boring, repeatable strike every time. Three simple keys make it happen:

The three keys

1 Use the club's own loft

Let the club do the work. Don't try to scoop or "help" the ball into the air — the loft on the face already lifts it. Trust it.

2
Hit slightly down on the ball Strike the ball first, then brush the grass. A gentle downward hit gives clean, predictable contact. This — not scooping — is what gets the ball up.

3
Swing straight back and through No twisting or flipping of the hands. Keep the path simple and the face quiet so the ball starts on line every time.

Set up the same way every time

Club sits flat Rest the middle of the sole flat on the ground — not toe-up or heel-up. Non-negotiable; a tilted club gives a glancing, unpredictable strike.

Chest over the ball Your breastbone (and nose) sits over the ball. This centers your low point so you catch ball-then-turf.

Lean onto your front foot About 60% of your weight on your lead foot at set-up — and keep it there. This helps you hit down and stops the fat/chunk.

Hands slightly ahead Set the handle a touch toward the target, hands just in front of the ball. Small lean — not a big forward press.

DRILL — Ball First, Then Turf

Lay a tee or a line of chalk just in front of the ball (target side). Make chips that brush the grass on the target side of the ball — never behind it. When your divots start after the ball, you've found the downward strike.

See it — LPGA star Charlie Hull's chip

Notice how **close her hands stay to her body** at address — arms relaxed and hanging, not reaching out. That's the quiet, connected set-up you're copying.



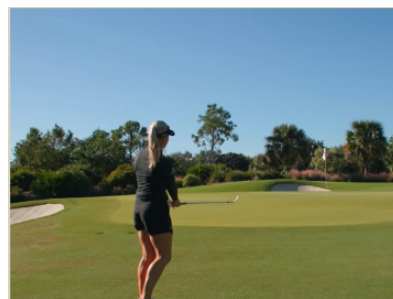
Address — up close

Hands hang close to the body, right under her chin



The full set-up

Tall & relaxed, weight into the lead side, ball back



Through the ball

Low and quiet — the body turns it to the target

SECTION 3

Pitching — Same Foundation, Bigger Swing

A pitch is your chip's taller sibling: it flies higher and longer with a fuller motion, but it's the **exact same Foundation Shot** — same three keys, same set-up. The engine gets bigger; the fundamentals don't change. Below is Rory McIlroy hitting a pitch, front-on. Watch four things.

The four things to watch

①

Lead hip moves forward

The near (lead) hip starts over the ball and drives toward the target through the shot. Your weight goes forward — you don't hang back.

②

Chest stays tall & level

The chest stays vertical with no lean to the side. He rotates around a steady, upright body — he doesn't tip or sway.

③

Trail wrist keeps its bend

Coming down to the ball the back (trail) wrist stays bent back — that's what holds the loft and delivers a crisp, downward strike instead of a scoop.

④

Club splits the triangle

Just after impact the shaft points straight down the middle of the triangle made by his arms and shoulders — proof the body led and the hands stayed quiet.



1 • Address

Tall & centered, weight forward



2 • Backswing

Chest turns, wrists set (top for a pitch)



3 • Downswing

Lead hip leads · trail wrist stays bent ③



4 • Impact

Ball first, hands lead



5 • Release

Club splits the triangle ④



6 • Finish

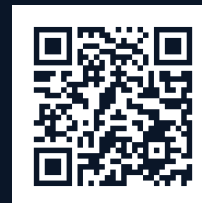
Fully through · hip cleared ①

Cyan arrows: chest stays vertical (upper) and lead hip drives forward (lower). Orange dashed shape: the arm-and-shoulder triangle the club swings down through.

Before every short-game shot, ask 3 questions:

- **How much loft** do I need?
- **How much speed** do I need?
- **How steep or shallow** should the swing be?

Answer those three and you can play a shot you've never practiced. That's the whole game.



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